

Editorial

Virtually Vocal

FIRST, PARDON ME for coming back to the topic of blogs, something about which I wrote in this space last month. But have you wondered why blogging, podcasting or even vlogging is such a rage today? All of a sudden, so many of us have the opportunity to be broadcasters or publishers, and have discovered the requisite talent in ourselves—resulting in an outpouring of thoughts. A new breed of blogaholics is writing five to ten times a day in their corners on the Web, while others have made such activity their sole profession.

Some well-known blogs are now being published as novels, and aim to be bestsellers in the USA. Jessica Cutler, a former Capitol Hill intern, traded inside secrets of her workplace on her blog *Washingtonienne*, and now it's a sought-after novel.

To me, this trend seems to be a reflection of a certain shift—from where the inherently introverted are expected to be submissive, to where anyone can afford to be individualistic, vocal and expressive. Private diaries in the days of ink-pens were shrouded in secrecy and a sense of privacy revolved around them, but blogs today carry an invitation to be read and criticised. So what has changed?

The Internet is the great leveller, as our publisher has said in his note. “*Why not me?*” seems to be the general idea. You’re as much a blogger as the next Blogspot or TypePad member. Not so in “real” life: in that other world, he or she is better-looking, more sociable, more chatty, more extroverted. His or her views are taken more seriously just because, for example, he or she is more articulate. We’re witnessing the great levelling act—where it does *not* matter whether you’re pretty or ugly, introverted or not. This reminds me of marriages that begin as online relationships: the focus is hardly on looks, as it is in the case of the traditional matrimonial proceedings. When the couple finally meet offline, looks take a backseat.

Second, everyone has this need to be rated, to be appreciated, to be *appraised*. Witness such sites as *ratepeople.com*, where people put up their photographs and wait to be rated on a scale of five, ostensibly by members of the opposite sex. Now with blogs, you can be sized up—from behind the comfort, in most cases, of a nickname. There’s also the need for acceptance by society: the Net is the new



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society, and blogs are the platform where one gauges how worthy one is. The introverts amongst us now have a level playing field, so to speak. It had to happen: way before blogs, the socially maladjusted had taken to the Net.

Most interesting, perhaps, is the need and capability to be a part of it all. To have an established voice on the Net is a matter of pride, not least because it can be accessed from anywhere at any time.

Virtual reality—as in the comical goggles—might have failed to deliver, as we speak about in this issue, but even apart from MMORPGs, the Net *is* virtual. It’s a reflection of *every* aspect of our brick-and-mortar lives, a more ideal expression; a new playground where it’s easier to arrive. The traditional shackles have been shed.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'D. Ajwani'.

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